CHAPTER 24

A G R I C U L T U R E I N T H E N E X T D E C A D E

EXPORT CROPS

In the late 1930's, fresh citrus fruits accounted for about three-quarters of the total value of Palestine's exports. Only two other groups of agricultural products accounted for more than one percent of the total value of exports. These were edible olive oil (1.4 percent in 1936-39) and hides and skins (2.3 percent in 1936-39). Due to the subsequent expansion of manufactures, citrus fruits will not again acquire their old dominance in total export trade. Citrus fruits must however continue, for many years to come, to be far more important in Palestine's <u>agricultural</u> exports than all other agricultural products together.

Citrus Expansion

There is much discussion in Palestine of the best methods of growing citrus fruits -- of the advantages of the various citrus stocks and varieties, the wisdom of lengthening the growing season, optimum planting densities, alternative irrigation systems, and the best cultivation methods. Broadly speaking, however, the citrus growing problem has been solved -- as completely as any growing problem is ever solved. A country where a first-class grove is expected to yield 400 cases of exportable fruit per acre has something to teach other citrus regions. Palestinian citriculture is clearly more expert and more successful than the citriculture of any other Mediterranean country, and it compares well with the most progressive citriculture of other regions.

Natural advantages and her drive towards intensive cultures (with a high input of capital and labor on a small area of land) combine to impel Palestine in the direction of further expansion of citriculture. She has sufficient suitable land so that, if world market conditions should warrant, she could easily double the planted area reached in 1938-39 and perhaps even triple it, without resorting to soils unsuited to citrus. Capable and dispassionate